COUNTRY REPORTS: RWANDA

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Status report

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Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Rwanda's overarching digital government strategy is in place but old and due for updating, and the whole-of-government transformation programme meant to carry it is only planned or in draft (2025). The national data strategy is in the same state, in progress rather than adopted, with the data governance documents behind it unpublished (2025), even though the data governance function itself is established, run by an autonomous institution and organised around government as a whole rather than system by system (2025).

AI is where the paper is thickest. The National Artificial Intelligence Policy, published in April 2023 by the Ministry of ICT and Innovation with RURA and external partners, carries fourteen recommendations and an implementation plan phased across FY23/24 to FY27/28 with indicators and lead institutions named for each activity, over six priority areas: skills and AI literacy, infrastructure and compute capacity, a data strategy, trustworthy public-sector adoption, widely beneficial private-sector adoption and practical ethical guidelines. The Responsible AI Office and the annual AI Readiness Index are recommendations of that policy, the Office to be established during its first year, rather than standing bodies or published instruments. Cabinet approved the establishment of a National AI Agency on 8 June 2026, to accelerate AI development, adoption, investment and governance.

Sector policy is more settled. The 2022 broadband policy is technology-neutral: it abandoned the single-wholesale-network model, let operators refarm spectrum, and allocated further spectrum in the 700, 900, 1800 and 2100 MHz bands. Delivery of the legacy-network transition runs through a working group of MINICT, RURA, the mobile operators, government institutions and the financial sector (July 2026). New instruments have kept arriving below the ageing strategy: Cabinet approved a National Data Sharing Policy in May 2025 as the framework for data exchange across public institutions, and a national digital public infrastructure strategy was launched in March 2026.

Rwanda scores 58.7 of 100 for Overall Governance in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 14th of 54 African states, up 0.8 points over the decade but flat across the most recent five years and down three places in rank (2023).

Legislation and regulation

Rwanda has legislated the end of its own paper identity documents: the Single Digital Identification Law makes the digital credential the only government identity a citizen may hold and voids the cards issued since 1962 by June 2027. The newest statute in the digital economy is the law on virtual assets: gazetted in May 2026 as the country's first dedicated legislation for virtual-asset businesses, it makes the Capital Market Authority their licensing and supervisory authority, after the Chamber of Deputies approved the rationale of the draft in April 2026.

The standing framework is older than the programmes running on it. The ICT Law of 2016 remains the sector's governing statute, covering cybersecurity and universal access, and the Law on Prevention and Punishment of Cybercrimes of 2018 covers digital signatures alongside criminal offences; the Supreme Court upheld its offence of publishing rumours online against a constitutional challenge on 5 June 2025. Much of the operative detail is regulator-made: RURA's 2018 e-waste regulation, its 2019 regulation on radio frequency management and its 2024 SIM card registration regulation, which binds every SIM to a biometrically verified national ID. Population registration runs on Law N° 029/2023, and payments on Law N° 61/2021, which lets the central bank own and operate the systems it regulates.

The most substantial recent instrument is subordinate law. Presidential Order n° 025/01 of 12 May 2023, gazetted on 15 May, repealed the 2004 order behind the Universal Access Fund. It widens the contributing base well beyond telephony, to network, application, content, broadcasting and postal services, and caps annual contributions at 2.5% of turnover for each category of regulated service (2023), leaving RURA's Regulatory Board to set the rate that is actually paid and to fix collection and sanctions. The Fund has no legal personality of its own: its staff are RURA's, its money is managed by RURA's Director General, and its annual account of the projects it financed goes to the Regulatory Board each 30 September rather than to the public.

The gap is between systems. The rules on whether public bodies connect and share their data sit in a policy instrument rather than in legislation. Data protection is the exception, fully enforceable since its grace period expired in October 2023.

Data protection

Rwanda's data protection supervisory authority sits inside the National Cyber Security Authority, and neither the regime nor the authority publishes any account of how it operates (2025). The powers are there: under Law N° 058/2021 the Authority oversees implementation, registers data controllers and processors and can impose administrative sanctions, and it has declared 2026 a year of accountability in which registered controllers and processors must prove compliance through documented policies and audits rather than registration alone. No formal investigation, fine or sanction had been disclosed by the authority in the one to two years to early 2026, and it publishes no complaint volumes (April 2026).

The law itself is demanding. Breach notification runs to a clock: a processor must tell the controller within 48 hours of becoming aware of a personal data breach, the controller must notify the Data Protection and Privacy Office in the same window, a full written report is due to the supervisory authority within 72 hours, and affected data subjects must be told where the breach poses a high risk to their rights. Personal data must be stored inside the country unless the supervisory authority authorises otherwise; the authority has published standard contractual clauses for transfers abroad (February 2024) and an application form for transfer authorisation asking for the contract, an impact assessment and a data-flow diagram, and keeps no list of adequate countries, assessing each transfer case by case (April 2026). and the Act reaches any global platform processing the personal data of Rwandans, wherever the processor is established. The World Bank records the law in force and rated effective, the authority in place with an oversight role, and compliance monitored (2025). Payments carry no separate privacy statute and are covered by the general regime under the Data Protection and Privacy Office.

No standing national body assesses AI risks or monitors AI errors and harms (2026). The EAC's newly approved regional rules on cross-border data flows and personal data protection must still pass the Community's decision-making organs before any partner state adopts them (July 2026).

The regime sits in a narrowing rights environment: Rwanda's Digital Freedom score fell 6.9 points over 2014-2023 to 37.7 of 100, 43rd of 54 African states (2023), and rights is one of the country's weakest governance sub-categories. A restriction on social media use by under-16s is in preparation; no text is published.

Regional collaboration

Rwanda's most widely exported government platform is its Electronic Billing Machine, taken up by Kenya and Uganda, while Guinea has adopted the Telemo procurement platform and is co-developing it with Rwanda rather than simply licensing it (July 2026). No revenue, contract value or licensing terms have been disclosed for any of these exports, so what the strategy earns is not on the record.

The diplomacy around it is active and largely unbinding. Rwanda and Kenya held talks in May 2026 on AI, data centres, digital infrastructure and talent, coordinated through Connected Africa and Smart Africa; Rwanda and Egypt signed a memorandum of understanding on AI and digital transformation at WSIS in July 2026, covering responsible AI, digital government, innovation and skills; and the Rwanda Information Society Authority and Guinea's digital-economy ministry identified AI, e-health and e-commerce as areas to explore at a meeting in Conakry on 20 July 2026. The central banks of Kenya and Rwanda agreed in March 2026 to work toward passporting payments licences between the two countries, so that a fintech licensed in one could operate in the other under coordinated supervision.

What crosses the border in practice is narrower than the paperwork. The national ID has been a recognised travel document for Kenya and Uganda since January 2014, permitting stays of up to six months, but the East African Community's regional rules on cross-border data flows and personal data protection remain unadopted. Smart Africa is preparing an Internet Governance Blueprint for its September 2026 steering committee and has proposed a Council of African Internet Governance Agencies, and the EAC's central bankers have agreed to build a peer review mechanism for macroeconomic surveillance alongside operational frameworks for the Community's 2026/27–2030/31 development strategy.

Rwanda ranks first of 54 African states on regional integration in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, scoring 75.1 of 100 after a 5.8-point decade gain (2023). Rwanda was selected on 21 September 2026 to host the seventh UN World Data Forum, expected in late 2028.

Standards

Rwanda has no government interoperability framework in force, no operational standard held over data quality or system uptime, and no programme retiring legacy systems to a standard (2025). Where standards are enforced on government systems it is through buying: the e-procurement system is in use, interfaces with other government systems and is used to hold what government buys to technical standards (2025).

The regulator has bought its own capacity to check. RURA spent Frw 500,000,000 on quality-of-service measurement equipment covering 4G LTE in financial year 2020/21, to measure the quality of the services telecom operators and internet providers deliver. Its published technical rules — radio frequency management and e-waste — remain the clearest standards on the books.

No open source policy for government is recorded (2025), though open source has shaped the biggest builds: more than 300 public websites run on one open-source content platform built by Rwandan developers (2024), and the domestic payment rail is built open-source on Mojaloop. The Rwanda Standards Board is the country's ISO member body, and it participates in 28 ISO committees and observes 12, including participating membership of the

subcommittee on IT service management and governance and observer status on the joint information technology committee and its security subcommittee (October 2026). Regionally, the EAC's Secure Data Sharing Framework was validated at a workshop in June 2026 and the rules that would follow it are not adopted.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Rwanda scores 0.0 out of 100 on freedom of association and assembly, the floor of its entire indicator range, and its Participation sub-category fell 5.2 points over the decade to 30.3, 38th of 54 African states, with civil society space down 11.8 points to 29.5 (2023). Rights is one of its three worst-performing sub-categories at 30.0, 42nd of 54 and down 4.0 points over the decade, with media freedom at 30.5 ranking 50th and freedom of expression and belief at 32.2 ranking 45th (2023). Digital freedom has fallen with them.

The machinery of participation, by contrast, is in place and rates well. A right-to-information regime is in force and rated effective, under which members of the public can obtain public records (2025), and the country's public records measures are among the continent's strongest and rising. The government operates participation platforms, including a separate portal for petitions, and citizen feedback channels through which complaints reach government (2025). Policy is consulted on before it is adopted: the 2023 national AI policy was built on a diagnostic assessment running to eight workshops and eight stakeholder surveys.

Involvement thins out as the service gets closer to the people who most depend on it. Citizens are involved in designing the services on the main service portal and the tax portal, but not on the social protection portal or the public jobs portal (2025). And the record a citizen would need to argue with is mostly held back: across the digital government estate — the service portal, e-procurement, the transformation programme, data governance, the participation and feedback platforms themselves, and the right-to-information regime — documentation and assessments are held internally and not published (2025).

Finance

Financial sustainability

Rwanda's own money carries 45.6 per cent of the digital lines in the 2026/27 finance law, RWF 92.1 billion of RWF 201.7 billion, against 50.0 per cent of RWF 176.0 billion in 2025/26 and 47.2 per cent of RWF 145.5 billion in 2024/25.

The fall is the identity build. The loan line for digital identification and authentication doubled to RWF 26.6 billion in 2026/27, from RWF 13.3 billion in 2025/26, and the World Bank credit that carries Single Digital ID enrolment, software and hardware, prioritised within an envelope cut by EUR 18.4 million in June 2024, closes in December 2026 with initial issuance targeted at 15 per cent of the population by then — six months before the old identity cards are voided (June 2027).

Most of what is voted is spent. In 2024/25 the ICT-for-development programme spent RWF 6.42 billion, national identification RWF 3.05 billion and cybersecurity standards and skills RWF 106 million, against RWF 8.72 billion, RWF 2.17 billion and RWF 921 million appropriated from domestic funds.

Two own-source mechanisms sit in law and contract rather than in the budget: the Universal Access Fund, levied on regulated services under a 2023 presidential order, and Irembo's commission on each paid transaction under a 25-year agreement, which pays for the service platform in place of a government fee. The platforms also earn abroad: Eswatini, Chad, Guinea and Kenya are paying to adopt Rwandan-built government platforms (July 2025).

MoUs and other agreements

The most consequential instrument signed in the past year is between regulators rather than governments: the National Bank of Rwanda and the Central Bank of Kenya agreed in March 2026 to build a passporting framework for payments licences, with supervision coordinated between them. In infrastructure, Broadband Systems Corporation, the state broadband operator, signed with Oman Data Park in May 2026 to invest jointly in an AI-ready Tier III data centre. Rwanda and Egypt signed a memorandum on artificial intelligence and digital transformation at WSIS in July 2026, covering responsible AI, digital government, innovation and skills. Rwanda and Jordan signed a digital transformation agreement at the UN General Assembly on 23 September 2026, with a joint technical committee to meet quarterly. Each of the four is an instrument of intent, with no money attached to it.

New investments

Rwanda's largest single digital commitment comes from a foundation rather than a development bank: the Mastercard Foundation's $275.7 million partnership with Carnegie Mellon University and the government, running to 2035, of which $175 million endows CMU-Africa in Kigali and $100.7 million funds a centre for inclusive digital transformation (2022).

The largest public commitment is the Rwanda Digital Acceleration Project, for which the World Bank approved $200 million in November 2021 across broadband, digital financial services, government platforms and skills, and to which AIIB is lending a further $100 million in its first digital investment in Sub-Saharan Africa (2022). The programme was about half complete (July 2025). Rwanda is not a borrower under the World Bank's $162 million Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project, whose borrowers are IGAD, Somalia, South Sudan and the East African Community (May 2023).

AFD made its first sovereign digital-transformation loan to Rwanda in 2023, a concessional EUR 37,000,000 — about $40 million at the time — for e-government including the Irembo platform. Korea returns most often: KOICA grants paid for the Revenue Authority's electronic billing system ($6 million, 2018), smart classrooms and teacher training ($7.3 million, 2024), the Digital Ambassador Programme ($4.5 million, 2022), ICT capacity at the Rwanda Standards Board ($8 million, 2024). Germany funds through KfW's ICT Facility (EUR 12,500,000, 2021) and its second phase (EUR 10,010,000, 2022), and BMZ's Digital4Rwanda (EUR 8,000,000, 2024). Japan's JICA established the 250STARTUPS incubation mechanism (JPY 500,000,000, to March 2022) and signed a JPY 2,009,000,000 grant in October 2023 for traffic control at twenty Kigali intersections.

Thirty-two distinct commitments are on the record, announced between 2017 and 2026, with funding windows running to 2035; twenty-one are active and eight have closed. Two-thirds are grants, alongside six loans, two equity investments, two technical cooperation projects and one political risk guarantee. Counted by number rather than by value, the most frequent financiers are Germany's BMZ and Korea's KOICA with five commitments each, the Gates Foundation with four, and the World Bank, KfW and JICA with three each. Two financing agreements worth a combined RWF 279 billion were approved by the Chamber of Deputies on 20 August 2026, funding broadband expansion and a labour-market information system among other measures, and Cabinet approved on 18 September 2026 a bill to ratify an IDA loan signed on 11 July for additional financing of a digital-adoption project, with no amount stated. Parliament ratified EUR 17m of additional financing for digital identity, public data management and cybersecurity, with the project deadline moved to 30 June 2028 (2026).

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Rwanda now has a fixed date for retiring 3G — 30 June 2027 for a nationwide shutdown, where the position before was talks on a gradual device phase-out with no date attached. The published sequence runs from pilot shutdowns during 2026, alongside 4G expansion and VoLTE verification, to migration of critical systems in the first half of 2027, with any extension temporary and needing the regulator's approval. December 2028 for 2G is a target the ministry says it is working towards rather than a deadline, conditional on how the 3G shutdown goes, on service continuity and on how many legacy handsets remain. The reason MINICT gives is operator economics rather than consumer benefit: running four generations at once "takes up valuable radio spectrum, increases network maintenance costs and limits investment in newer technologies".

What the switch-off exposes is the distance between reach and use. 4G covered 99% of the population (2022), while 34.4% of people used the internet (2024); unique mobile subscriber penetration was 39% (2023), against the SIM-connections figure of 86.2% usually quoted, and smartphone penetration was 22% (2023), below the East African average of 32% and the sub-Saharan average of 49%. A mobile broadband basket costs 3.0% of gross national income per head (2022). The independent read splits the same way: mobile communications scored 79.4 of 100 12th of 54 African states (2023), while internet and computers scored 27.2, 33rd of 54 and among Rwanda's ten worst measures.

Behind the access networks the picture is thinner. Rwanda has about 20 kbit/s of international bandwidth per internet user (2022), and its exchange point RINEX carries members including MTN and Liquid (2024) but averaged 1.53 Gbps inbound and 1.97 Gbps outbound in financial year 2020/21. The sector runs under the ICT Law of 2016, a 2019 spectrum regulation and a 2022 broadband policy spanning last-mile connectivity, spectrum and skills, which abandoned the single-wholesale-network model — the same instinct that saw RURA unwind KT Corporation's 4G monopoly in 2023. MTN's data subscribers grew 14.1% to 2.8 million (March 2026), and it has begun carrying voice over its 4G network. A 2,000 km protected terrestrial fibre route from Goma to Mombasa through Kigali, Kampala and Nairobi is live and carrying wholesale traffic, alongside an earlier terrestrial-only route from Mombasa to Johannesburg through Rwanda launched in May 2023 that Google's Umoja route to Australia runs over; and Uganda, Kenya, Rwanda and South Sudan opened a joint account in August 2026 to fund a feasibility study for a regional communications satellite. The World Bank's mission put the project's disbursement at 49.73% on 13 March 2026, up from 40% in November 2025, and processed US$20m of additional financing with an 18-month extension.

Data Storage

Rwanda runs a government cloud and does not publish the arrangements behind it (2025). The platform is in use across central and local government, deployed as a hybrid and providing infrastructure-as-a-service (2025), sits alongside a national data centre and a cloud-first strategy with a national public cloud (2024), and requires government data to be kept inside the country (2025) — a rule that runs with the grain of the localisation duty in the data protection law. The estate depends on a grid whose reliability firms still report as a constraint.

Commercially the country is East Africa's smallest colocation market, with about four live commercial data centre facilities (2024), and the nearest hyperscale capacity sits well to the south, Google's first Africa cloud region having opened in South Africa in January 2024. The state's answer is to court investment: an October 2025 digital FDI roadmap aimed at cloud and data infrastructure, and in May 2026 a memorandum between the state broadband operator BSC and Oman Data Park to invest jointly in a data centre for cloud and AI workloads — signed in front of ICT ministers and RISA's chief executive, which places it inside the state's own infrastructure programme rather than beside it. What the build-out does not yet have is a resource plan: domestic analysis in March 2026 argued that

Rwanda needs a water policy for data centres before it scales them, cooling being the demand nobody has budgeted for. The acceleration project tendered IT equipment for a government disaster recovery site in October 2025, with no location or award stated.

Energy

Access to energy is at once one of Rwanda's ten most improved and ten worst-scoring measures: it rose 18.9 points over 2014-2023 and still reaches only 27.4 of 100, 34th of 54 African states (2023). That is the shape of the whole sector — fast movement from a very low starting point, which is still visible in the result. The utility reports cumulative household access of 84.6% (July 2025), 59.6% on the grid and 25.0% off-grid, against around 6% in 2008 and a target of universal access by 2029; a quarter of the country's electrified households are therefore served by systems that are not the grid at all. The gap is geographic: urban access stood at 99.9% against 57.9% in rural areas (2023), 42 percentage points apart.

Supply is workable but not dependable. Firms reported roughly 1.8 outages a month, about 22 a year (2023) — enough to make a data-dependent business buy its own backup, not enough to stop it operating. Price is where the burden falls unevenly. Regulated residential tariffs from 1 October 2025 charge RWF 89 per kWh for the first 20 kWh a month, RWF 310 between 20 and 50 kWh, and RWF 369 above that: a lifeline block that is genuinely cheap, and a cliff immediately above it for any household running more than lighting and a phone charger. About half of generation and capacity was renewable in financial year 2023/24.

Power now limits connectivity rather than the other way round: the obstacles to connecting Rwanda's still-unconnected schools were named in March 2026 as electricity supply, affordability and maintenance rather than network reach. Infrastructure remains Rwanda's weakest of the four foundations for economic opportunity, at 40.0 of 100 and 25th of 54 (2023), barely moved over the decade.

Technical Capacity

The finance ministry completed an upgrade of the integrated financial management information system in October 2026, replacing legacy components that had reached the end of their support, and will apply the same blueprint to the schools data system and the SACCO core banking system.

Rwanda's working developer base is around 1,000 active GitHub users (2024), the band that marks a developing rather than an established software industry — a thin pool for a state whose public administration is rated Africa's most effective. The institutional capacity is well ahead of the labour market it draws on.

The state has met that gap by insourcing deliberately. Irembo is built and maintained by an insourced local engineering team rather than an offshore vendor, and the delivery model for the national data-sharing platform pairs an experienced external firm with internal experts so that knowledge transfer and ownership stay with the state. The information society authority's own software division maintains and upgrades four central government systems free of charge (2024).

Inside government there is both a digital skills strategy for the public service and a training programme delivering it, covering advanced skills as well as basic literacy and free to take (2025). The floor is lower than the ceiling suggests: a 2025 study of one rural district found that ICT literacy gaps and limited connectivity and computer access mean some case documentation is still taken on paper before digital entry. A UNDP regional review of September 2026 reports country-hosted AI compute capacity deployed under its programme, with 42 priority applications identified across eight sectors; no capacity or host institution is given.

Cybersecurity

Rwanda sits in the top band of the ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, the tier it reserves for role-modelling states, on the strength of a strategy written eleven years earlier: the National Cyber Security Strategic Plan of 2015 is still the strategy instrument on record. The binding law is newer — the Law on Prevention and Punishment of Cybercrimes of 2018 is in force and also covers digital signatures — and breaches of personal data must be notified on short statutory deadlines.

The institutional design concentrates the two roles in one body: the National Cyber Security Authority is also the data protection supervisory authority, registering controllers and processors and imposing sanctions, so the agency charged with defending the state's estate is the same one that polices how the state handles people's data. The reach extends to the networks themselves, with SIM registrations verified against the national biometric database, and to the funding instruments: protection of Rwandan cyberspace is an eligible use of the Universal Access Fund.

Capacity-building has arrived more recently than the strategy. The National Cyber Security Authority opened a Cyber Security Centre of Excellence, CyberHub, at the University of Rwanda's College of Science and Technology in October 2025, combining a cyber academy, an innovation hub and technical labs with partners including Cisco and GIZ, and Cabinet approved a post-secondary institute in AI and cybersecurity in July 2026. The prime minister said reported fraud complaints over digital payments were about 30% lower in the second quarter of 2026 than the 4,128 of a year earlier.

The central bank reported on 8 October 2026 that fraud cases fell to 2,879 in the second quarter of 2026 from 4,128 a year earlier, while only 3.6% of the Rwf471 million involved had been recovered.

DPI

Data Exchange

Rwanda's government-wide data exchange platform is still being built: the Data Sharing Platform envisaged by the National Data Sharing Policy was still being procured and developed in 2025, and in October 2026 the information society authority described the existing Data Sharing Platform as an interim system for data governance, discovery and access while a shared government data hub moves into implementation, with cross-government integration running meanwhile over the Rwanda Information Society Authority's Government Enterprise Service Bus and bilateral system-to-system links.

That bus is doing real work. Sixteen government systems — the identification agency, the revenue authority, the central bank and the social security board among them — interoperate through it, and the core financial management, customs, tax administration, public-service HR, social insurance, debt and procurement systems exchange data with one another both through direct interfaces and over a Government Service Bus. The identification agency supplies the electoral commission with lists of citizens reaching voting age, a link the two bodies confirmed in 2024 had been automated so that the voter register updates as citizens turn 18.

What is missing is the rulebook over the pipe. The World Bank's 2025 GovTech Maturity Index update records no government interoperability framework, no operational standard held over data quality or system uptime, no programme retiring legacy systems to a standard, and nothing published on the data-sovereignty terms of government data exchange.

Cabinet approved a National Data Sharing Policy on 26 May 2025, positioning government data as open by default and casting institutions as stewards rather than owners of what they hold, adopting the Five Safes framework for controlled access — a policy instrument, not a statute. Implementation is phased to 2029, with the Data Governance

Unit to be established in 2025 and the data-sharing platform project running from 2025 to 2027, and responsibility split between the National Institute of Statistics, whose Data Governance Unit owns standards, and RISA, which runs the platform itself.

A Centre of Digital Public Infrastructure was established in 2025 and a national DPI strategy launched on 9 March 2026. The government's own reason for it is that Rwanda's digital platforms were developed independently and were not designed to communicate with one another.

Digital Identity and CRVS

About 4.4 million people had completed biometric enrolment in Rwanda's Single Digital Identity system by June 2026, as the country prepared for a full transition to digital identity by 2027.

Nationwide enrolment opened on 7 August 2025, with biometric capture following from mid-September. At 16 March 2026 the count stood at 2,373,854 against a target population of about 14 million, enrolling at roughly 40,000 a day.

That was around 17% of the population, leaving roughly 11.6 million people to enrol before the legacy cards are voided in June 2027.

The credential has three parts: a Single Digital Identification Number unique to the holder for life, a transaction-specific token derived from it, and a physical card carrying a QR code readable only after authentication. It is built on the civil registration system, linking parent–child family trees, and collects a deliberately small biographic set. The 2025 Auditor-General's report found the legacy system issued a fresh 16-digit number on every correction or replacement, so one person could accumulate several, breaking banking, land, SIM, voting and pension records that assume one number each.

The population register underneath it is a centralised electronic database covering approximately 98% of the population (2023). Law No. 14/2008 makes the card obligatory from age 16 and the legally recognised proof of identity, Law N 029/2023 governs registration in the new system, and a first card costs RWF 500, a replacement RWF 1,500 (2020). Holding one is a condition of ordinary life: a bank account, community-based health insurance and public healthcare, and social protection registration all require it (2020), and every SIM registration is verified biometrically against the agency's records.

There is no identity-specific judicial oversight; grievances run through administrative review before the agency and then judicial review, and institutional access to the database rests on memoranda of understanding rather than on binding legislation; over 50 ministries, departments and agencies had an API integration with the national ID database (2024). The card has been a recognised travel document for Kenya and Uganda since January 2014. By 16 September 2026 more than 10 million people had been photographed and biometrically captured across 27 of 30 districts, against about 14 million. The identification agency suspended the photography exercise for the digital identity card, naming no resumption date, while pre-enrolment continues online (2026).

Digital Payments and Fintech

All domestic interoperable retail payments in Rwanda moved onto eKash, the national instant payment rail, on 14 July 2026 under a central bank directive.

The rail carries instant transfers between any bank or e-money provider, and merchant payment from any account over customers' existing USSD, app and internet-banking channels, to a ceiling of RWF 10 million (2026). It is built open-source on Mojaloop by RSwitch with the Rwandan firm Wiredin, a deliberate break from the proprietary infrastructure of its first iteration, and launched on 27 February 2025.

Across borders the rail is being linked rather than duplicated: the central bank governor said in October 2026 that a pilot integrating eKash with Tanzania's instant payment system was under way, and that Rwanda routes intra-EAC payments through the regional EAC payment system and payments beyond the EAC through PAPSS.

Pricing is where the reform stops short. The RWF 20 transfer fee cap binds off-net interoperable transfers only — those between institutions and between e-money issuers — and institutions are free to waive it; on-net tariffs are unchanged and not governed by the cap.

The National Bank of Rwanda operates the country's real-time gross settlement system directly and acts as settlement agent for eKash, settling participant positions once daily through it — a role Law N 61/2021 provides for, empowering it to establish, own and operate clearing and settlement systems. It also oversees eKash's availability, transaction performance, consumer protection and complaint resolution and reports payment-system performance twice yearly. eKash publishes its scheme rules, the only instant payment system in Africa to do so as at 2023. Article 33 of the same law requires operators to appoint an external auditor accredited by the central bank, but no audit findings specific to eKash have been published.

Citizens can pay the state through IremboGov by mobile money, bank card or bank transfer; paying out is programme by programme, with social security pensions fully digital since 2022 while Vision Umurenge cash transfers only began moving from collection at SACCOs to direct mobile money, in three districts, in August 2025.

Scheme governance runs through a National Payment Council chaired by the central bank and through eKash's participant-owned board, with no dedicated consumer advisory body, no reserved seat for small or non-bank providers and no explicit pro-poor mandate in the governance charter. A February 2026 policy dialogue found physically inaccessible bank and operator premises and no disability-tailored products. Since its national launch eKash has carried more than 10.5 million transactions and moved over RWF 960 billion at a 98.6 per cent success rate, the central bank acknowledging that users still report delays and failed transfers (September 2026). The central bank opened a national campaign against cash on its own data showing 85.3% of Rwandans holding a digital account while 92% still mainly pay in cash, and the registration portal the value added tax order on online services required by 29 July 2026 was not in place in mid-September, on a practitioner's account. The central bank governor said a digital agricultural lending platform is in a six-month pilot with four lenders, meant to cut farmers' wait for a loan from weeks to under 48 hours. The central bank reported active accounts on the national payment switch at 10.3 million in September 2026, against 2.03 million a year earlier, and a rejection rate below 2%. The Bank of Ghana said in October 2026 that it is testing payment interoperability with Rwanda across central bank digital currencies, stablecoins, bank accounts and mobile wallets.

Registries

Rwanda's Imibereho social registry, live since early 2024, has handled 360,000 classification appeals and corrected 93% of them.

The registry covers 13.8 million people (2025). It classifies households by cross-referencing self-reported income against social security and tax records, is validated and deduplicated against national ID data and is integrated with more than ten government systems (2025). Its dominant source of misclassification is stale asset records — households that sold land or vehicles without completing the legal transfer are still scored as owners — a linkage failure rather than misreporting.

Land is the deepest register. Tenure regularisation demarcated 10.4 million parcels, issued 8.8 million titles and put every land record in a digital registry nationwide under the e-Title system, and the Land Administration Information System connects to more than 14 other government systems (2026). A six-month correction exercise in Kayonza issued more than 28,000 titles to 17 June 2026, leaving about 4,700 untitled for ownership disputes, bank mortgages and government wetland wrongly registered to individuals.

The business register is complete in form, thin in coverage. Registration is fully online and free, with a certificate issued within six working hours and a single Taxpayer Identification Number issued as part of the process, but only 36,706 of an estimated 278,060 enterprises were formally registered in 2024, 13.2%. The tax register is tied to the national identity system for individual taxpayers, while institutional taxpayers are registered under other identifiers.

Civil registration runs on a national centralised system that is digital at every level from health facilities and cells through sectors and districts to embassies and generates a unique national identification number linked to the population register on registration. Birth registration completeness reached 92.9% in 2025, from 90.3% in 2024. Deaths in the community moved off paper in 2026: village leaders now notify each one from a basic phone with the deceased's national ID number, the system introduced nationwide in spring 2026 and logging about 10,000 community deaths in its first months, where community events were notified on paper first in 2023. The voter register is a fully electronic extract from the identification agency's population database, every citizen entered on turning 18 and identified at the polls by national ID card.

Sectoral management information systems

Rwanda's tax administration is the most digitised part of the line-ministry estate — the e-Tax platform, Electronic Billing Machines reporting sales in real time, API integration with banks and mobile-money operators — and a senior Rwanda Revenue Authority official has said that data fragmented across systems still limits full interoperability.

The public financial core is custom-built rather than bought. The integrated financial management system is in use, custom-built and covers both central and local government; a treasury single account is used extensively by all ministries, departments and agencies, settling through both the real-time gross settlement system and a clearing-house system; customs and tax administration run on hybrids of custom and commercial software; and public debt and public investment run on two further custom systems. The public-service HR and payroll systems are likewise custom-built, most HR services are digitised, and the HR system uses the national identity number rather than an identifier of its own. Social insurance is in use on a hybrid platform, its pension management serving public employees alongside the general scheme.

Health splits sharply between the aggregate layer and the record layer. The health information system has run on DHIS2 since 2012, with data completeness rising from 88% to 95% and timeliness from 60% to over 90%, and a National Health Intelligence Centre established. At the point of care it is thinner: a 2024 assessment of 215 health centres found a minority had any electronic medical record system deployed, and the Ministry of Health's e-Ubuzima platform, meant to replace paper registers at all of the country's health centres, was operating in 15 districts as at April 2025. The national services platform's operator described a patient-facing health platform in September 2026, letting patients see their records and track them across facilities, with no launch date or user figure published.

Education statistics run on the School Data Management System, covering pre-primary, primary, secondary and technical education, and the education ministry has introduced a digital attendance system to identify learners at risk of dropping out (December 2025). In justice, the sector and its stakeholders began using an upgraded Integrated Electronic Case Management System in January 2025. The Chief Justice named technology a major focus of the 2026/27 judicial year, opened on 4 September 2026. The health ministry's statistical booklet for 2023/24 was compiled from the health management information system by facility level.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

IremboGov now carries more than 600 government services, of which more than 240 are paid — and it is the paid services, not the total, that generate the commission revenue funding the platform.

Irembo is a single-window services platform launched in 2015 out of a partnership between a private company and the government, run under a 25-year agreement to digitise and maintain public services, funded by a commission on each successful paid transaction rather than a fixed government fee, which ties the operator's revenue to actual citizen usage. Roughly 4,000 field agents, the digital ambassadors, transact on behalf of citizens who cannot use the platform themselves. Irembo took the award for Best Government Service in the World at the GovTech Prize 2026 in February 2026.

The national service portal is transactional at level 3 or 4, meaning services can be applied for and completed online end to end rather than only described. A business can be formed and registered through it; a public jobs portal is in use; the e-procurement system covers open tendering and contract management, interfaces with other government systems, and is used to enforce technical standards on what government buys. E-passports are issued through the same platform, requiring an identity number and biometric capture, alongside an Advance Passenger Information exchange with airlines under Law n 57/2018. The public-service HR platform serves employee records verified against the national ID to partner systems through an API.

The measured position is strong on administration and middling on e-government proper. Rwanda ranks first of 54 African states for public administration in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, at 77.2 of 100 in 2023 and sits in the top group of the World Bank's 2025 GovTech Maturity Index alongside Kenya, Tanzania, Uganda and Egypt, but scored 0.5799 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024, in the High band rather than Very High. An established institution coordinates digital government, with a designated leader, inter-institutional machinery, and coordination and audit functions recorded as in place — though documentation across most of the estate is held internally rather than published.

Kenya and Uganda have adopted Rwanda's Electronic Billing Machine, and Guinea has taken up the Telemo e-procurement system and is co-developing it. The national e-government platform carries 248 public services from close to 50 institutions, and the civil-status certificates issued through it rose from 683,560 in 2020 to 1,977,628 in 2024.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The sector office is becoming Rwanda's permanent counter for identity: biometric kits are to be deployed permanently to sector offices so registration continues after the nationwide campaign (June 2026). The tier beneath it already carries real administrative load — civil registration is decentralised to cell and sector level and has been kept exclusively in electronic form since February 2020, the cell office being where community-notified events are entered. On the finance side, the integrated financial management system in use covers local as well as central government (2025).

What the tier does not yet have is a channel of its own. The government announced in October 2025 that it was building Mbaza, a platform for citizens to raise and track issues across local-government institutions, integrating with the Irembo service portal and the civil registration system and replacing the older e-Citizen platform. A Kigali trial was set for January 2026, following the digitalisation of records across all 416 of Rwanda's sectors.

Donors have funded the lower tier directly rather than as an afterthought to national systems: KfW is supporting the decentralisation agency's monitoring and information system for the lower tiers of administration to 2028, and French lending in January 2023 covered local alongside central e-government systems.

The revenue authority's 2023 account describes its local government tax system, in service since 2015, as linked to the land registry by parcel identifier and integrated with the identity agency and banks, with property tax about 30% of local revenue.

Rural digital data capture

In rural Nyaruguru district, a study of the integrated electronic case management system found it improving access to justice services, with ICT literacy and infrastructure limits the challenges (2023). The same gap between where a record arises and where it becomes data runs through civil registration: events in a community rather than a health facility are registered by the cell executive secretary on information provided by the village head, while facility births and deaths are captured at the point of service.

Elsewhere these are rollouts in progress rather than systems in place. The health ministry's replacement for paper registers at health centres was short of national coverage in April 2025. The education ministry has introduced a digital attendance system to identify learners at risk of dropping out (December 2025). Land is the exception: nationwide tenure regularisation has put the rural parcel base into one register, and correction drives are reworking its boundary errors district by district.

What stops the rest is rarely the network. Rural electricity access ran far behind urban in 2023, and the obstacles to connecting schools still without internet are power, affordability and maintenance rather than coverage.

Where the state has paid for last-mile capacity, placement has not always followed need. Rwanda's Universal Access and Service Fund subsidised bandwidth at 193 rural and remote institution sites at Frw 100,000,000 a year in financial year 2020/21, and in the same year paid Frw 96,000,000 for two telecommunications towers built inside Nyungwe National Park at the request of local authorities — siting driven by local political request rather than by coverage modelling.

The rural base itself is strong on assets and weakening on connection to markets. Rwanda's rural economy scored 77.8 of 100 in 2023, fourth of 54 African states, with rural land and water access first at 93.1 and rural economy support second at 90.1. Against that, rural market access fell 15.5 points over 2014-2023 to 59.8 and 24th place, its second most deteriorated measure, with rural representation and participation also down, to 68.1 at 25th.

A company's solar-powered connectivity and power unit for health posts, deployed with the health ministry and a vaccine alliance and launched on 1 October 2026, has reached 65 health posts in 21 districts, with 85 more planned.

Technology

AI

A three-year memorandum of understanding, non-binding and signed in February 2026, put Anthropic's Claude across Rwanda's health ministry, its public-sector agencies and its education system, supplying Claude and Claude Code along with API credits to government developers, and a Claude-based learning companion built with ALX reaches students in Rwanda and other African countries (March 2026).

The instrument behind this is the National Artificial Intelligence Policy, which covers artificial intelligence and machine learning alongside e-government services, e-commerce, digital market regulation, specialised skills, startups, regulatory sandboxes, technology hubs and payments; Cabinet approved the establishment of a national AI

agency on 8 June 2026 to carry it, and approved an advanced institute of computing in artificial intelligence and cybersecurity, hosted by the University of Rwanda, on 24 July 2026. The first binding rules are sectoral: the central bank's Guidelines 52/2026, in force from 4 June 2026 with six months to comply, require financial institutions to keep an inventory of their AI systems, including generative and agentic ones, and to assess their impact and fairness.

What is running is thinner than what is signed. The ICT ministry puts AI in use in health and education service delivery (July 2026), and the Gates Foundation and OpenAI are funding a programme to apply AI tools to primary healthcare delivery, with implementation beginning in Rwanda (January 2026). Inside government, the ministry ran targeted AI training for chief digital officers in March 2026, covering generative AI and responsible-deployment governance, aimed at moving AI beyond experimentation and into service delivery. The statistics institute built a model that assigns classification codes to labour force survey responses in three languages, coding 96 per cent of records automatically in one test run (October 2026).

The data layer is being built to match: the digital public infrastructure strategy launched in March 2026 is positioned as the foundation the country's AI ambitions will run on. Regionally, Rwanda's ICT and innovation minister frames the East African AI push in sovereignty terms, that regional data "stays in our hands" and that the value AI generates should accrue to East Africans (March 2026), while the bloc's central bank governors called in July 2026 for regulatory harmonisation on artificial intelligence and digital finance, a call that remains unadopted.

ICT Industry

MTN Rwanda returned to profit in the first quarter of 2026, posting Rwf 10.8bn (about $6.8m) after tax against a loss a year earlier, on service revenue up 14.7% and an EBITDA margin of 35.8%, carried by data and by growth in its mobile money business. One foreign-owned operator's quarterly results are the largest single fact about the sector as an economy, and the country's ICT-service exports run at only a few dollars per head of population (2025).

The conditions the sector operates in are the strongest thing about it. Rwanda scored 85.7 of 100 on business and competition regulation in 2023, third of 54 African states and up 3.7 points over the decade, and a business can be formed and registered online through the government service portal (2025).

What sits inside those conditions is small. The active developer community is in the range typical of a developing rather than an established software industry (2024), and venture funding into Rwandan startups falls short of the level associated with a settled market. Sector organisation runs substantially on external money: Germany's development ministry is funding a project pairing the German IT-SME federation with Rwanda's ICT Chamber to 2027, following an earlier partnership between the same two bodies aimed at employment and competitiveness in the Rwandan ICT sector, and KOICA is funding a project with the Rwanda Standards Board putting ICT tools behind standards compliance for SMEs to 2028.

Innovation ecosystem

Rwandan startups raised about USD 26 million in equity venture funding in 2024, a place among Africa's top ten markets — the clearest measure of a sector that is real, visible and still sub-scale. It ranks 104th of 133 economies in the WIPO Global Innovation Index 2024, leading the low-income country group.

Activity is concentrated in financial technology, and that is where the institutional scaffolding has gone. The Rwanda FinTech Centre, a one-stop hub run by the ICT ministry with the ICT Chamber, the Kigali International Financial Centre, the Rwanda FinTech Association and Luxembourg Cooperation, was inaugurated in March 2026, alongside a FinTech Strategy 2024–2029 intended to diversify the sector beyond payments. A regulatory sandbox for fintech

held its second Demo Day in 2026, and the ministry's Hanga Ventures Ignite programme showcases inclusion-focused startups, among them Kayko in SME finance and bookkeeping and Save Directly with a "Save Now, Buy Later" product (May 2026).

The physical and financial scaffolding is largely donor- and partner-built. Kigali Innovation City, a 60-hectare technopark developed as a public-private partnership with the Rwanda Development Board and comprising offices, a technology incubator and four planned universities, broke ground in September 2024. The EU is funding Hanga Hubs, innovation and incubation hubs in the secondary cities of Muhanga, Nyagatare, Rubavu and Rusizi to 2026; JICA established the 250STARTUPS early-incubation mechanism and three secondary-city hubs and now runs a follow-on project to 2026 on supplying entrepreneurs and building public-private support around them; and the AIIB-financed Rwanda Digital Acceleration Project carries a digital innovation and entrepreneurship component.

On the public side, government runs a public-sector innovation programme with an established institution behind it, working on digital skills and public-service innovation (2025), and domestic build capability has been demonstrated at national scale — the eKash instant payment system was developed domestically on an open-source architecture, with support from partners including AfricaNenda.

Capacity

Literacy

Almost every Rwandan school has a computer and only a minority teach with one: 97.4% of schools held at least one computer in the 2023/24 school year and the teacher-to-computer ratio had improved to 2:1, but just under two-thirds had internet connectivity and only around a third reported actively using ICT in teaching and learning.

The school system underneath is better staffed than it is finished. Rwanda's human resources in education score reached 91.7 of 100 in 2023, 13th of 54 in Africa and up 7.3 points over the decade, but the Education sub-category as a whole scored 59.1, 18th of 54 and up only 1.4 points across the same ten years, with enrolment at 40.2 and completion at 41.3 its two weakest components. The direction of travel on the other two measures is downward: education quality fell 3.8 points over the decade to 50.5 and equality in education fell 6.2 points to 71.7 (2023). A country that has solved teacher supply has not yet solved whether children stay, whether what they get is good, or whether it reaches everyone equally.

Nor is the third of schools using ICT evenly spread. School internet access divides sharply between rural and urban Rwanda (March 2026), which puts the classrooms most dependent on digital delivery furthest from it, and the connectivity for unconnected schools written into the Digital Acceleration Project is the standing answer to it.

Administration is further ahead than teaching. Primary schools, rural ones included, report through the School Data Management System, which covers pre-primary, primary, secondary and technical education, and the education ministry has introduced a digital attendance system to flag pupils at risk of dropping out (December 2025). The teaching side has been built by donors: Korean grant funding through 2024 established ICT smart classrooms as centres of excellence in secondary schools, trained teachers in ICT integration and produced an ICT competency curriculum.

Training and skills

Cabinet approved a Rwanda Institute of Computing on 24 July 2026, an advanced post-secondary institution in AI and cybersecurity hosted by the University of Rwanda and expected to launch in September 2026, presented as the continuation of the Rwanda Coding Academy pipeline. It had not opened as at August 2026.

The standing instrument behind all of this is old: a National Digital Talent Policy dating from 2017. For the public service specifically, Rwanda has both a digital skills strategy and a training programme delivering it, covering advanced digital skills as well as basic digital literacy (2025). Newer priorities arrive through the AI track rather than through the talent policy: the National AI Policy puts 21st-century skills and AI literacy first among its six priority areas, and MINICT ran targeted AI training for government Chief Digital Officers in March 2026, covering generative AI, real use cases and responsible-deployment governance, facilitated by Cenfri and aimed at moving AI out of experimentation and into service delivery.

Most of the delivery capacity sits in institutions set up with outside partners. GIZ runs a Digital Transformation Center in Kigali with the Rwanda Information Society Authority on public-sector innovation and digital skills; the National Cyber Security Authority's CyberHub at the University of Rwanda's College of Science and Technology, opened in October 2025, carries a cyber academy alongside its labs; and the Mastercard Foundation's partnership with Carnegie Mellon and the government, running to 2035 is the largest skills commitment in the sector. Tertiary ICT teaching itself rests on the University of Rwanda and its predecessor institutions.

At the population end, the Digital Ambassadors Programme, run by the Ministry of ICT and Innovation since 2017 to teach basic digital skills and funded in its final phase by a Korean grant that deployed ambassadors nationwide, concluded in May 2026. Nothing of comparable reach has been announced to replace it. Cybersecurity is being introduced in technical and vocational schools, a first cohort of 24 teachers having completed a ten-day training-of-trainers programme (September 2026).

Research institutions

The largest single commitment in Rwanda's digital sector is a university one. The Mastercard Foundation is funding a $275.7 million partnership with Carnegie Mellon University and the Government of Rwanda running to 2035 — a $175 million endowment for CMU-Africa in Kigali and $100.7 million for a new Center for the Inclusive Digital Transformation of Africa, the Upanzi Network — targeting 10,000 young Africans in digital skills and digital transformation careers (2022). The same campus carries a $6 million Gates Foundation grant running 2021–2026 for work on scaling the digital stack in Africa, aimed at digital capacity and infrastructure for financial inclusion, growth and governance.

That concentration is the point: the best-funded research base in the country is an overseas university's African campus rather than a domestic institute, with the University of Rwanda and its predecessor institutions carrying the national side. On the output measure that ranks countries against each other, Rwanda placed 104th of 133 economies in the WIPO Global Innovation Index 2024, ahead of every other low-income country — first in its group and in the bottom quarter of the world.

Inclusion

Access to services

Rwanda's weakest showing in the Ibrahim Index is on what reaches people rather than what is built: equal access to public services scored 27.3 of 100 in 2023, 41st of 54, and equal socioeconomic opportunity 20.4, 47th and down 10.2 points over the decade. The most recent movement is downwards — enrolment in Mutuelle de Santé, the community health insurance scheme, has fallen to 51% from 63% a year earlier (August 2026).

The identity credential is the gate in front of most of this. It is required to open a bank account, to enrol in community health insurance and to register for social protection, and it is not issued free of charge. Eligibility is deliberately wide: the digital ID covers residents, refugees, asylum seekers, migrants and stateless people, and enrolment has been extended to the roughly 70,000 residents of the Mahama refugee camp (June 2026), and the immigration

authority ran a dedicated registration drive for foreigners and refugees in Kigali from 7 to 15 February 2026 at sites separate from the citizen campaign. Biometric kits are to be deployed permanently to sector offices, so registration continues after the nationwide campaign (June 2026).

Channels that do not assume a smartphone still carry much of the load. MINICT publishes USSD codes — *4561#* on MTN and *2555*4#* on Airtel — that let any subscriber check whether their SIM is 4G-capable without visiting a shop; the new interoperable payment system runs over customers' existing USSD, app and internet-banking channels with no new app required; and the government service platform rests on field agents who transact on behalf of citizens who cannot use it directly. More than nine in ten adults are financially included, with the central bank's deputy governor putting the remaining problem as depth rather than access, though formal banking access remains one of the country's weakest measures.

Where digital authentication fails, remediation can require in-person verification within limited service hours. The stated response is the Rwanda Digital Acceleration Project, whose components run to smart-device affordability measures, digital-literacy programmes and connectivity for schools, hospitals and markets that are not yet connected.

The development board announced a planned Business Obstacles Alert platform on 8 October 2026, for businesses to report and track obstacles in accessing public services after registration.

Digital divides

About 27% of rural Rwandan schools have an internet connection against about 75% of urban ones, and 812 schools remain unconnected altogether — 62% of schools were connected by late 2024, against a national target of 80%. What holds the remainder back is electricity supply, affordability and maintenance rather than network reach.

That geography runs through the rest of it. The national household survey records a persistent urban-rural digital divide, with Kigali significantly better connected than rural districts, and it sits on top of an electricity gap that still leaves rural households far behind urban ones. Against those, the gender line is narrow: women are less likely than men to use mobile internet by a margin that is small by regional standards. Disability is the sharpest measured divide, with persons with disabilities markedly less financially included than other adults and their formal saving falling since 2020. A central bank campaign closed in September 2026 having brought 615,000 women into mobile financial services against a target of 150,000.

Coverage is not what limits use. The networks reach effectively the whole country while internet use and smartphone ownership sit far below it, so what separates people is devices, money and skills rather than reach. Handset affordability is written into the government's 3G switch-off plan, which expects a substantial population still on 2G handsets towards the end of the decade.

Inclusion & Equality is Rwanda's worst-ranked measure in the Ibrahim Index, at 30.4 of 100 in 2023, 44th of 54 African states and down 4.6 points over the decade. The public money aimed at the gap runs through the Universal Access and Service Fund, which in financial year 2020/21 financed 68 completed passive-infrastructure sites at Frw 2,698,636,500 and identified a further 45, at Frw 1,158,668,676, that the operators' own business case would not carry. Assessments of the digitalisation agenda since find that some users still depend on assisted access rather than transacting for themselves.

Data

National statistics

Rwanda's Capacity of the Statistical System score reached 74.3 out of 100 in 2023, fourth of 54 African states and up 5.5 points over the previous decade. The weakness is in what the system is fed rather than in what it does with what it has: on the World Bank's 2023 Statistical Performance Indicators Rwanda scores above 89% on data use, between 70% and 89% on data services, data products and data infrastructure, and only 50-69% on data sources, the weakest of the five pillars. The same assessment records a population census, an agricultural census and an economic or business census all run within the previous ten years, and three or more household, labour force, health, agricultural and business surveys over that period. NISR's microdata catalogue held 75 datasets and 74,146 variables on 15 October 2026, access on request, the newest the 2025 labour force survey.

Vital statistics are published annually and are current: the 2025 report from the National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda puts birth-registration completeness at 92.9%, against 90.3% a year earlier, on 356,838 recorded births. The administrative registers that might carry part of the load the surveys carry are uneven. The Imibereho social registry reaches close to the whole population, but most of the enterprises NISR counted in its 2024 business survey are not on the formal register, and the Auditor-General found in 2025 that the legacy identity system let one person accumulate several national identity numbers.

The counting stops short of the country's own governance record: the 2024 IIAG profile carries no data at all for 14 of its 96 indicators on Rwanda, which scores above the continental average on 56 of them. The office's remit now runs past measurement into the terms on which government data moves, with NISR leading the Data Governance Unit under the National Data Sharing Policy and its work on unified national identifiers. A UN regional hub for big data and data science, hosted in Kigali with the statistics institute, supports African statistical offices in using new data sources for official statistics.

Open data

Rwanda has an open data portal, but it carries only basic information and datasets and is updated mostly by hand rather than automatically from the systems that hold the data. Neither its holdings nor its licensing terms were published in 2025. Procurement data is the exception: since November 2024 the procurement authority's open contracting portal has published contract data from the Umucyo e-procurement system back to 2016 in the Open Contracting Data Standard, by download or API. The pattern is wider than the portal: across the digital government estate — the service portal, e-procurement, the digital transformation programme, data governance, customs, payroll, tax administration, the participation and feedback platforms and the right-to-information regime among them — documentation and assessments are held internally and not published. The national data strategy is planned rather than adopted, and the hosting arrangements behind the government cloud are not disclosed either.

What is published sits in the middle of the range. On the Open Data Inventory's 2024 assessment, population and vital statistics at 7.5 out of 10 and national accounts at 7.0 are the strongest categories, with pollution and health facilities at 4.5 and no category reaching eight.

Across the 23 categories the Open Data Inventory scores for Rwanda in 2024, the mean is 5.3 out of 10, or 5.6 setting aside the unscored communications and digital infrastructure category.

The right to ask for what is not published is in better shape than the publishing. Rwanda's right-to-information regime is in force and rated effective, and members of the public can obtain public records under it; on the 2024 IIAG measures, accessibility of public records scored 61.5 out of 100 in 2023, third of 54 and up 7.4 points over the decade, and disclosure of public records 54.3, fifth and up 7.5. Against that, neither the data protection regime nor

the data protection authority publishes reporting on how the regime operates, and no revenue, contract value or licensing terms have been disclosed for Rwanda's exports of its government platforms (July 2026). One system runs the other way: on AfricaNenda's 2023 review, eKash was the only instant payment system in Africa to publish its scheme rules.

Use of satellite data

The Rwanda Space Agency is now the gatekeeper for satellite internet as much as for imagery: it certified the state-linked Broadband Systems Corporation as a Starlink reseller (February 2026). It also operates a GeoHub applying satellite and geospatial data to agriculture and urban planning (2025). The geospatial capacity was built with external money: an Agence Française de Développement package agreed in January 2023 covered the GeoHub, the agency itself and a drone operations centre at Huye. Weather forecasting uses less of what it receives: the meteorological service takes EUMETSAT feeds but uses them mainly as static images for forecasters rather than as data for its models (July 2026).

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The most consequential American arrival is a model vendor rather than a cloud one: a three-year, non-binding memorandum of understanding signed in February 2026 places Anthropic's Claude across Rwanda's health ministry, other public-sector agencies and education, with Claude and Claude Code and API credits supplied to government developers.

The other US presence is philanthropic and corporate rather than governmental. The Gates Foundation and OpenAI are funding Horizon1000, a programme applying AI tools to primary healthcare delivery whose implementation begins in Rwanda (January 2026).

China activities

Bank of Kigali, Rwanda's largest bank, joined China's Cross-Border Interbank Payment System as a direct participant under an agreement signed in Xiamen on 8 September 2026, the first bank in Rwanda to do so, giving it renminbi clearing and settlement without intermediary banks. The state's own ties to China in the digital programme run through public lending: China Eximbank extended a concessional loan to the Government of Rwanda in 2022 for a Smart Education Project.

EU activities

Germany's money goes to the machinery of the state rather than to networks: KfW funds the ICT Facility Rwanda, a EUR 12,500,000 grant running 2021–2030 for the efficiency of state action through ICT, and a second phase of EUR 10,010,000 running 2022–2030; separately it funds a EUR 8,000,000 grant over 2019–2028 building a modernised monitoring, evaluation and information system for the lower tiers of administration through LODA, the agency that finances district infrastructure. BMZ funds Digital4Rwanda, a EUR 8,000,000 grant over 2024–2027 aimed at groups still excluded from digital infrastructure, skills and services, women and rural populations in particular, and pairs the German IT-SME federation BITMi with Rwanda's ICT Chamber over 2025–2027.

France entered later and at the centre of the system: AFD made its first sovereign digital-transformation loan to Rwanda in 2023, concessional, supporting the expansion of digital public services including the Irembo e-service platform and digital ID. The European Union's own money is smaller and sits outside the capital: Hanga Hubs, a EUR 1,137,500 grant over 2021–2026, creates innovation and incubation hubs in Muhanga, Nyagatare, Rubavu and Rusizi, and a EUR 2,000,000 programme over 2020–2030 works on youth skills and digital-based opportunities in

four secondary cities. Sweden's contribution is institutional rather than financial in character, channelling support over 2022–2027 through Lantmäteriet, its own mapping, cadastre and land-registration authority, to Rwanda's National Land Authority.

European public financiers are the largest group of external digital commitments to Rwanda by number, though the individual commitments are comparatively small.

Gulf/UAE activities

Rwanda has been courting Gulf capital in the Gulf's own rooms: it launched its Digital FDI roadmap at the 9th Future Investment Initiative in Riyadh in October 2025, alongside the Saudi-headquartered Digital Cooperation Organization, making Gulf money an explicit target of its data-infrastructure investment strategy.

What has followed so far is an intention rather than a build. Broadband Systems Corporation, the state broadband operator, holds a memorandum of understanding with Oman Data Park, signed in May 2026, to invest jointly in an AI-ready Tier III data centre; ministers of the Ministry of ICT and Innovation and RISA's chief executive Antoine Sebera witnessed the signing, placing it inside the state's own digital-infrastructure programme rather than beside it.

India activities

No Indian-financed digital infrastructure or India Stack-derived system was operating in Rwanda as at August 2026. Senior digital officials joined a UNDP-hosted learning mission to India on its digital public infrastructure in September 2026.

Digital sovereignty

Rwanda's own ICT sector plan puts only 14.9 per cent of the government's 4,660 websites and applications hosted in the country, despite a 50 per cent cut in hosting prices at the National Data Centre (2025), against a rule that government data be kept inside the country (2025) and a data protection law requiring personal data to be stored in Rwanda unless the supervisory authority authorises otherwise.

The next shared platform is designed to straddle the border: the government data hub RISA took to market in November 2025 puts its core hardware in colocation at the National Data Centre and lets cloud components, for work such as model training on GPUs, run on public cloud outside Rwanda. The region's first AWS Outposts deployment, by Sand Technologies, went into Rwanda in 2026 to keep data from services such as health and public administration stored and processed in the country. The terms on which that deployment and the February 2026 memorandum placing Anthropic's Claude across the health ministry and other public agencies govern data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026.

The core systems the state has rebuilt it has rebuilt to keep: Irembo is maintained by an insourced local engineering team, and the eKash payment rail was rebuilt open-source on Mojaloop with a Rwandan firm, replacing a proprietary first version.

On AI, the prime minister set out three tests of sovereignty in September 2026 — whether a state can govern the data its citizens produce, whether its institutions can reach infrastructure on terms they can predict, and whether African firms earn margin or only distribute — and named affordable compute and energy as the country's biggest constraints. Huawei offered Rwanda a three-tier "trustworthy and sovereign AI" model, starting from a base model built locally on local data by local engineers (September 2026). Regionally, Rwanda hosted the EAC meeting on a shared AI roadmap framed as regional sovereignty (March 2026), while the Community's cross-border data rules remained unadopted (July 2026).

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